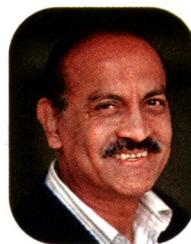


What's on the Menu?



At their first summit in 1994 the then US president Bill Clinton and the late prime minister Narasimha Rao spent much of their time discussing, of all things, almonds. The US had concerns about why India preferred to import them from Iran instead of California. When Prime Minister Manmohan Singh meets President Barack Obama at the White House on November 24, they should not let themselves fall into the same trap but instead focus on the big picture. Obama is giving Manmohan the signal honour of being the first head of state he is hosting and there is much buzz about the menu, including a dish of chicken tikka masala. All this is at best, in keeping with the food metaphor, a great entrée but it can't be the main course.

What the two don't have so far is the Big Idea like that of the path-breaking Indo-US nuclear deal that George Bush and Manmohan fathered. The deal brought the two nations closer than they were ever before. It is a fact that relations with India do not figure as high on US priorities in the current administration. Obama is too focused internally on issues such as health care and the recession and externally with what needs to be done in Iraq and the Afghanistan-Pakistan mess. And much to India's discomfort the US now treats China with kid gloves. Instead of moaning, as is our wont, Manmohan should take Bush's friendly advice "to get on with it". Manmohan should tell Obama of how he sees India's growing role not only in the region but also in world affairs. That India's Navy can play a major role in collaboration with the US to ensure the smooth flow of maritime trade in the Indian Ocean. In a

way it would create for India a larger necklace than China's string of pearls strategy for the region. India's purchase list of arms, one of the longest in the world, is a big hook. On the economic front, Manmohan could discuss with Obama how to remove the bottlenecks in their trade relations and ways with which the two countries could help each other's economies get out of the recession quickly. They could even explore the possibility of having a free trade agreement in future. Then there are global issues such as climate change that India and the US should work hard to find common ground on despite their differences. They could start by announcing a few signature collaborations in the area of green-tech, especially solar energy. There are major collaborations possible too in the areas of health and agriculture. In short, there are plenty of exciting medium-sized ideas around that could add up. So both Manmohan and Obama should have much more to talk about when they meet than just almonds.



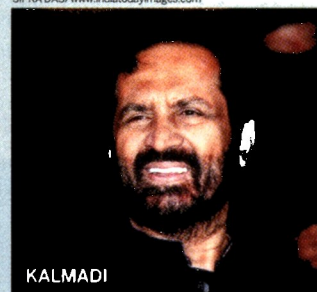
SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: R.V. Subramanian, one of the first batch of 1947 IAS officers. He had been secretary, Ministry of Energy, and adviser to the governors of Tamil Nadu, Assam and Punjab during President's Rule in those states.

ELECTED: Suresh Kalmadi as the president of the Asian Athletics Association for the third consecutive term till 2013.

SIPRA DAS/www.indiatodayimages.com



DIED: Prabhash Joshi, 73, journalist and founder-editor of the Hindi daily *Jansatta*.

CREATED: By Sarfraz Khan, an Under-12 school cricket record when he scored an unbeaten 439 in the Harris Shield inter-school tournament. The earlier record was by S. Jadhav (427 not out in 1963-64)

CONFERRED: On Dr. Karan Singh, President of Indian Council of Cultural Relations, the Honorary Doctorate of Humane Letters by the State University of New York for his impact on philosophy, culture, education and environment.